

Acceptable Use Policy

Policy Summary & Knowledge Check

Authority	Chief Operating Officer
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Delegate(s)	Senior Manager, Information Systems

Policy Summary

The Acceptable Use Policy sets out employees' responsibilities when using USC corporate IT systems (computers, email, network, and software). Corporate systems are provided for business purposes and must be used to protect the USC's public image, security, and data, and to comply with University of Western Ontario network policies since USC systems are hosted on Western's network. The policy covers acceptable personal use, system security, monitoring of activity, data protection, use of personal devices when working remotely, and the consequences of violations, which range from verbal warnings to termination and potential criminal referral.

Key Takeaways

- Corporate systems are for business purposes; use that conflicts with USC's interests or breaches policy is prohibited.
- Because USC is hosted on Western's network, Western's confidentiality and information-governance policies also apply.
- No abusive, discriminatory, harassing, inflammatory, profane, pornographic, or offensive material may be sent through corporate systems, and messages may never be sent anonymously or under a fictitious name.
- Limited personal use is allowed only if it doesn't interfere with work, involve solicitation, support an outside for-profit activity, or risk embarrassing the USC.
- Unauthorized, unlicensed, or pirated software is strictly prohibited; antivirus software must never be disabled, and virus incidents must be reported.
- Login IDs and passwords are personal and must not be shared or written down; employees are responsible for all activity under their own ID and must report any suspected compromise to I.S.
- USC Information Systems management may monitor usage patterns, web history, and email to maintain a safe and productive work environment.
- Employees are legally and ethically responsible for protecting any sensitive, confidential, restricted, or proprietary data entrusted to them.
- Personal devices used to access USC data while working from home must be patched, run up-to-date security software, and be password protected.
- Confirmed violations can result in sanctions up to and including termination, and may be referred to authorities for criminal prosecution.

Knowledge Check

Five situational questions to check understanding of this policy. An answer key follows on the next page.

Q1. An employee wants to use their USC email and cloud storage to help run a small side business they own, only during their unpaid lunch break. Is this acceptable under the policy?

- A.** Yes, as long as it's limited to unpaid break time.
- B.** No — personal use must not be associated with any for-profit outside business activity, regardless of timing.

- C. Yes, if their manager gives verbal approval.
- D. Yes, as long as it's under 30 minutes per day.

Q2. A colleague is locked out of their own account and asks to use your login just this once to finish an urgent task. What should you do?

- A. Share your credentials since it's a one-time favour for a colleague.
- B. Share your credentials, then change your password afterward.
- C. Decline — employees must use only their own log-on ID and password, and credentials must not be shared.
- D. Share your credentials only if you stay logged in to supervise.

Q3. Your work laptop has been running slowly, and you suspect the antivirus software is the cause. What does the policy require?

- A. You may disable it temporarily and re-enable it the same day.
- B. You must not disable antivirus software; report the issue instead.
- C. You may disable it outside of business hours.
- D. You may disable it if you notify a coworker first.

Q4. After a frustrating call with a vendor, an employee sends a profanity-laced, angry email about them using the corporate email system. Which part of the policy does this violate?

- A. Section 3, Personal Use.
- B. Section 2, Corporate Public Image, which prohibits abusive or profane communications through corporate systems.
- C. Section 6, Data Protection.
- D. Section 7, Working From Home.

Q5. An employee is working from home on their personal laptop and needs to store USC member files locally to complete a project. What must be true of that laptop under the policy?

- A. Nothing additional is required, since it is the employee's own device.
- B. It must be patched to the latest secure version, run up-to-date security software, and be password protected.
- C. The files must be printed rather than stored digitally.
- D. It only needs COO approval to be used this way.

Answer Key

Q1: B — Section 3.1 states personal use must not be associated with any for-profit outside business activity — timing doesn't change that.

Q2: C — Section 4.2 requires personnel to use their own log-on ID and password only, and prohibits sharing credentials.

Q3: B — Section 4.1 states users must not disable antivirus software and should report virus occurrences.

Q4: B — Section 2.1 prohibits abusive, discriminatory, harassing, inflammatory, profane, or offensive communications on corporate systems.

Q5: B — Section 7.1 requires personal devices accessing USC data to be patched, running current security software, and password protected.